

VIKING WEAPONRY AND ARMOUR

The Vikings were warriors from Scandinavia who carried out raids across northwest Europe from about 800 to 1050CE, also reaching Russia, Iceland, and Greenland. Renowned as individual fighters, they defended from behind a wall of shields before emerging to strike their opponents. Their main weapon was an axe, though many also carried long, straight double-edged swords, while some brandished a single-edged, shorter version, the seax. Most were lightly armoured with leather or, occasionally, mail coats, and carried heavy shields.

Short sleeve allows arm to move freely



Large, decorated pommel



▲ PATTERN-WELDED SWORD

Date 700–800CE

Origin Denmark

Weight 1.5kg (3¼lb)

Length 90cm (35in)

Many Viking swords, such as this one, were pattern-welded. This process involves adding carbon to red-hot iron and a number of rods, which are twisted together and hammered flat repeatedly to give a patterned appearance.

Wing on either side



▲ DOUBLE-EDGED SWORD

Date 800–1100CE

Origin Denmark

Weight 1.5kg (3¼lb)

Length 90cm (35in)

This blade, like most Viking swords, is quite blunt at the tip, as it was used for slashing and cutting rather than stabbing. The fuller – a groove that runs the length of the sword – makes it lighter and easier to use.

Shaped plates make up dome

◀ MAIL COAT

Date c.1000CE

Origin Northern Europe

Material Iron

Mail coats had iron links – as visible on this modern replica – that were formed by winding iron wire tightly around a metal pole, then clipping individual coils from the spiral. Coats of mail could weigh up to 14kg (30lb) and were usually only worn by richer Vikings.

Links riveted individually



Dome composed of four plates

Spectacled visor protects eyes and nose

▲ GJERMUNDBU HELMET

Date c.875CE

Origin Norway

Material Iron

Made from four iron plates, this helmet was found near Gjermedbu in Norway, in 1943. It is thought to have been used by Norsemen in the Viking Period.

Animal decoration



► SWEDISH HELMET

Date 700–800CE

Origin Sweden

Material Iron

This helmet with a spectacled visor was found in a grave at Vendel in Sweden. Very few Viking helmets have been found, compared with axes and swords.

Nasal guard offers nose protection